

AIGLEON LABS RESEARCH

The Funnel Leak Report

Why most leads never make it from ad click to sale

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Aigleon Labs

The Problem

Most businesses that run ads assume that if the offer is good enough, the sale will follow. So when it doesn't, the instinct is to blame the ad. Change the creative, tweak the targeting, raise the budget. But the ad is rarely where the loss actually happens. It happens after the click, in a handful of specific, fixable spots that have nothing to do with how good the offer was.

The honest starting number is this: industry benchmarks put average website conversion at just 1.8 to 2.9 percent. That means for every hundred people who click through already interested enough to look, ninety seven or more leave without buying or enquiring. That gap isn't mostly a story about weak interest. Interest was already proven the moment someone clicked. It's a story about what happens to that interest once it's inside the business's hands.

A useful way to think about it is as a leak, not a wall. Nothing dramatically stops a lead from becoming a customer. Instead, a little bit of momentum is lost at each handoff: how long it takes someone to respond, whether anyone follows up more than once, and whether the page a lead actually lands on matches what the ad told them they'd find. None of these show up on an ad dashboard. All of them are entirely within the business's control.

This report walks through three of the most common leak points, in the order a lead actually experiences them: the response gap, the follow-up gap, and the message match gap. Each section covers what the leak looks like, what it costs when it's left alone, and a clear way to close it.

Sources: industry conversion rate benchmarks (Baymard Institute, Smart Insights, Triple Whale); Google Ads Quality Score documentation.

Leak Point 1: The Response Gap

What the leak is

The response gap is the time between a lead raising their hand, filling a form, sending a message, calling in, and the business actually getting back to them. For most businesses this isn't a decision, it's just whatever happens to be left over after everything else that's already on someone's plate.

What happens if it's left open

A person reaching out to a business is very often reaching out to two or three of its competitors at the same time. The gap doesn't need to be huge to matter. It only needs to be bigger than the gap the next business leaves. Once that happens, the lead has usually already committed to whoever answered first, regardless of who would have offered the better service or the better price. Left unmanaged, response time tends to drift outward too, since without a fixed rule it depends entirely on how busy that particular hour happens to be, so the business's win rate quietly starts to depend on luck rather than on demand.

Proof of loss

Research from MIT and Harvard Business Review, tracking large sets of real sales leads, found that a business is up to 100 times more likely to actually reach a lead when it calls within five minutes rather than thirty, and roughly 21 times more likely to qualify that lead. Separate research puts the figure even more simply: 78 percent of customers buy from whichever business responds to them first. Despite this, the average business takes somewhere between 42 and 47 hours to respond to a new lead.

The solution

Set a maximum reply window and write it down as a rule, not a hope: under five minutes for a chat or call enquiry, under one hour for a form or email, with no exceptions for busy days. Pair it with an instant acknowledgement, even a short automated one, that goes out the moment a lead comes in, so the wait feels handled while a real reply follows shortly after. Most importantly, make the response someone's specific job at that moment, whether that's one person, a shared inbox with an alert, or a simple rota, rather than a task that belongs to whoever happens to be free.

Leak Point 2: The Follow-Up Gap

What the leak is

The follow-up gap is what happens after the first contact attempt, when a lead doesn't reply straight away and the business simply stops trying. It's a different failure to the response gap. A business can reply within minutes and still lose the sale here, if that first reply is the only attempt it ever makes.

What happens if it's left open

Almost no real buyer says yes on the first message. Most are still comparing, still busy, or simply not ready yet, and a single unanswered attempt gets read by the business as disinterest when it's usually nothing more than bad timing. A lead that would have converted on the third or fourth touch instead quietly disappears after the first one, and because it never technically said no, nobody notices it's gone. Over time this becomes one of the largest silent leaks in the funnel, since the leads lost this way are often the ones that were closest to buying, not the least interested ones.

Proof of loss

Across multiple sales studies, roughly 44 percent of salespeople give up after a single follow-up attempt, even though around 80 percent of sales are reported to need five or more touches to close, and only about 2 percent of sales happen on the very first contact. The gap between how many attempts it actually takes and how many most businesses are willing to make is where a large share of otherwise winnable deals are lost.

The solution

Build a fixed follow-up sequence in advance, for example five touches spread across roughly two weeks, mixing a call, a message, and an email rather than repeating the same one. Put the schedule on a calendar or a simple reminder system so it runs whether or not anyone remembers to do it manually. Treat a lead's silence as the default state to work through, not a signal to stop, until they've either bought or clearly said no.

Leak Point 3: The Message Match Gap

What the leak is

The message match gap is the disconnect between what an ad promises and what the page it links to actually shows. It happens whenever every ad, regardless of what it says, sends its traffic to the same general homepage instead of a page built around that specific offer.

What happens if it's left open

A person clicks an ad because something specific in it caught their attention, a price, a product, an offer. If the page that opens doesn't immediately continue that same thread, they don't go searching the site for it. They assume they've landed in the wrong place and leave, often within seconds. The business still pays for that click either way. The interest was real and the ad did its job, the loss happens entirely on the business's own page, which makes it one of the more frustrating leaks since it's also one of the more visible and fixable ones.

Proof of loss

Google explicitly factors ad-to-landing-page relevance into Quality Score, which affects both how often an ad is shown and how much each click costs, so a mismatch is penalised twice, once on conversion and once on ad cost. Industry analysis of ad accounts that replaced a generic, mismatched landing page with one built specifically around the ad's offer has found conversion rate improvements of 50 percent or more from that change alone.

The solution

Build one landing page per distinct offer instead of routing every ad to the same homepage, and mirror the ad's exact headline, wording, and imagery on that page so the visitor recognises they've arrived in the right place. Keep the page's next step limited to the one thing the ad actually promised, rather than presenting every product or service the business offers. Start by auditing the last five ads run and checking each one against the page it currently sends traffic to, then fix the pairing with the highest spend and the weakest match first.

Quick Self-Check

Answer honestly. Two questions for each leak point, and an honest read on where the funnel actually stands today matters more than a clean score.

1. Every new lead gets a reply within the hour, even outside business hours.
2. Lead response is one specific person's job, not whoever happens to be free.
3. A lead who doesn't reply gets more than one follow-up attempt.
4. Follow-up attempts are planned in advance, not improvised in the moment.
5. Each ad sends traffic to a page built for that specific offer, not the general homepage.
6. The headline and offer on the ad match what's on the landing page it opens.

Two or more no's on any single leak point mean that's where the funnel is losing the most, and where fixing it first will show up fastest.

What To Do Next

Of the three leaks, the response gap is usually the cheapest to close first. It needs no new page, no new sequence, just a rule that gets followed. Here's where to start, in order.

- 1.** Set a maximum reply window (five minutes for chat or calls, one hour for forms and email) and write it down as a rule, not an intention.
- 2.** Assign lead response to one person, one shared inbox, or one rota, so it's never simply whoever happens to be free.
- 3.** Build a fixed follow-up sequence of at least five touches over roughly two weeks, and put the schedule on a calendar instead of relying on memory.
- 4.** Pull up the last five ads run and check each one against the page it currently sends traffic to.
- 5.** Fix the worst mismatch first, the pairing with the highest ad spend and the weakest match to a dedicated page.

About Aigleon Labs

Aigleon Labs works with mid tier luxury and premium brands, the kind built on craft rather than volume, where every detail is made with care rather than mass produced. We build the acquisition, conversion, review, and retention systems that let a brand's actual quality come through online, without flattening what makes it particular in the first place.

Book a free audit and we'll walk through exactly where your own funnel is leaking.